CHAPTER 6

Optimizing Active Record

Now the focus switches away from PostgreSQL and SQL and to the Active Record query layer in your Rails application.

You'll see a variety of ways to improve the performance of your application by eliminating unnecessary queries, using caches, and using advanced query designs.

Active Record is the *Domain Specific Language* (DSL) that Rails developers use to create SQL queries from Ruby code. Queries are generated and fragments of queries as Ruby code can be composed together.

If you've written SQL before and are newer to Rails, you may wonder whether writing your queries as Active Record is worth it. You may prefer to write SQL directly. What are some of the reasons to prefer Active Record?

Preferring Active Record Over SQL

Active Record has always been the sole built-in ORM framework for Ruby on Rails. Ruby on Rails is one of the most popular open source Ruby projects, meaning many developers learned Ruby primarily in working with the Ruby on Rails framework.

As a full-stack framework, Ruby on Rails has always been opinionated or "prescriptive", including all of the major layers needed to build web applications, especially an ORM that connects Ruby language objects and instances to database tables and rows.

Rails advocates for *Convention Over Configuration* as a design philosophy. Active Record is the conventional way to describe your application data model and do write queries. Whether a developer is familiar with SQL or not, by embracing the conventional way to write queries, a team may have an easier time growing their contributor base and maintaining their application.